

that vision. The product improved every day, but Farb wanted to make sure those improvements mattered to customers. I believe he deserves a lot of credit for realizing this. Unlike many visionaries, who cling to their original vision no matter what, Farb was willing to put his vision to the test.

Farb worked hard to sustain his team's belief that Grockit was destined for success. He was worried that morale would suffer if anyone thought that the person steering the ship was uncertain about which direction to go. Farb himself wasn't sure if his team would embrace a true learning culture. After all, this was part of the grand bargain of agile development: engineers agree to adapt the product to the business's constantly changing requirements but are not responsible for the quality of those business decisions.

Agile is an efficient system of development from the point of view of the developers. It allows them to stay focused on creating features and technical designs. An attempt to introduce the need to learn into that process could undermine productivity.

(Lean manufacturing faced similar problems when it was introduced in factories. Managers were used to focusing on the utilization rate of each machine. Factories were designed to keep machines running at full capacity as much of the time as possible. Viewed from the perspective of the machine, that is efficient, but from the point of view of the productivity of the entire factory, it is wildly inefficient at times. As they say in systems theory, that which optimizes one part of the system necessarily undermines the system as a whole.)

What Farb and his team didn't realize was that Grockit's progress was being measured by vanity metrics: the total number of customers and the total number of questions answered. That was what was causing his team to spin its wheels; those metrics gave the team the sensation of forward motion even though the company was making little progress. What's interesting is how closely Farb's method followed superficial aspects of the Lean Startup learning milestones: they shipped an early product and established some baseline metrics. They had relatively short iterations, each of which was judged by its ability to improve customer metrics.